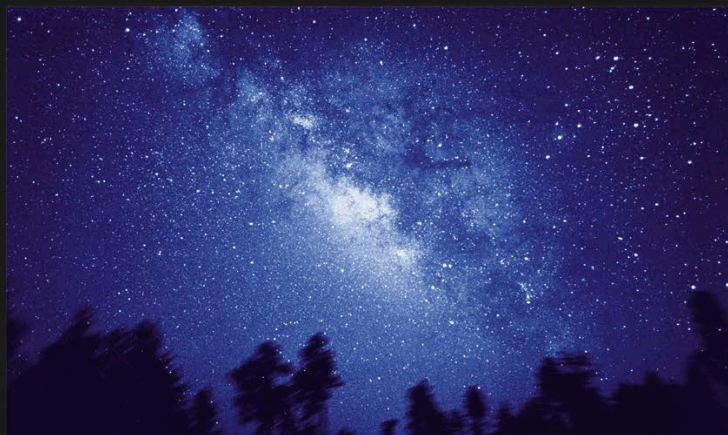


# The Milky Way

Our solar system is a tiny part of a gigantic barred spiral galaxy, the Milky Way. This is made up of billions of stars, which look as if they have been sprinkled thickly onto the night sky.



Scientists think there are about 400,000 million stars in the Milky Way galaxy, but there may be even more.

## Why is it milky?

Before the invention of telescopes, people could not see the stars very clearly – they were blurred together in a hazy white streak. The ancient Greeks called this streak a “river of milk”. This is how our galaxy became known as the Milky Way.

## Turn and learn

Stargazers:

**pp. 8-9**

Our solar system:

**pp. 50-51**

## Milky myths

Many myths have developed about the formation of the Milky Way.



### Native American

stories tell of a dog dropping corn as he fled across the sky.



**Hindu** myth sees the milky way as the speckled belly of a dolphin.



### Kalahari bushmen

say it was created by hot embers thrown up from a fire.



The **ancient Egyptians** believed the stars were a pool of cow's milk.

## A side view

The Milky Way, like all spiral and barred spiral galaxies, is flat, with a bulge at the centre, and arms that circle outwards.